The Goblins

By A.J. Jacobs

INTRODUCTION

One of the most successful and beloved of Victorian fairy tales, George Macdonald's ***The Princess and the Goblin*** *tells the story of young Princess Irene and her friend Curdie, who must outwit the threatening goblins who live in caves beneath her mountain home.*

This version of the story by A.J. Jacobs – simply called "The Goblins" modifies the original a bit to fit the format of what the world has come to know as "Fractured Fairy Tales" If you ever watched the Rocky and Bullwinkle show on Saturday mornings as a child, you may remember this one!

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A long, long, long time ago, a little kingdom sat perched on top of a high mountain. The king of the kingdom was constantly trying to raise money for things he thought the country needed. Like, for instance, another robe for the king.

"That robe-the one with the lion fur around the collar?" the king told his prime minister. "Got to

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have it. I'll have to levy another tax on the little people."

"But we already have a tax on everything, Your Majesty," said the prime minister. "What can you tax them for?"

"Easy! I'll just tax them for being little people." And so the king levied a tax on all people under four feet six. Problem was, there weren't that many people *that* little. Matter of fact, only one family in the kingdom was under four feet six. The Goblins. And they didn't like it a bit.

"We may not have height, but we got heart!" father Goblin told the tax collector who banged on his door. "We may not have altitude, but we got attitude. We may not have-"

"All right, I got the point," said the tax collector. "But if you're going to live on this mountain, you gotta pay the tax."

"Well, then," said the goblin, "we won't live on the mountain. We'll live *in* the mountain."

And with that, the entire Goblin family

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entered a hole in the side of the mountain and slammed the door shut, vowing to come out only on moonlit nights to try to get the big people. But as we said, that was a long, long, long time ago. After many years passed by, the kingdom entered the era officially known as a long time ago. (We'll skip the era called a long, long time ago.) Anyway, a long time ago, the goblins still lived inside the mountain and still sallied forth to try to get people. Although, it should be said they had never actually gotten a person, and wouldn't really know what to do if they did.

The reason the goblins had never actually gotten someone was that they had a weakness: poetry. Repeat a couple of lines-something like "One, two, buckle my shoe, three, four, shut the door"-and the goblins were stopped cold. Repeat a couple more lines-for instance, "I should have been a pair of ragged claws scuttling across the floors of silent seas"-and the goblins ran away, screaming.

One day, the new king was teaching his

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daughter, Irene, the facts of life.

"And remember, the goblins will get you if you don't watch out!"

"Oh, yeah?" said Irene. "Have you ever seen a goblin?"

"Umm, no, but ... "

"Well, how do you know there are even such things as goblins? Is that a goblin?" asked Irene, pointing to a red couch.

"No, but-"

"Is *that* a goblin?" asked Irene, pointing to a brass candlestick.

"Um, no."

"Is *that* a goblin?" asked Irene, pointing to a little, four-foot, three-inch man with an evil glint in his eyes.

"Why, yes," said the king. "I believe that *is* a goblin."

And with that, the goblin began chasing Princess Irene around the castle and out the door and over the moat and into the kingdom.

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"I'm gonna get you!" the goblin cackled.

"I don't want to be *got!* I don't want to be got!" shouted Irene.

Things looked bad for the princess until she bumped into a young miner named Curdy, and he was so struck by the princess's beauty that he was moved to poetry.

"Oh, Princess fair," said Curdy. "Your golden hair. Upon your head. I see it there."

And of course, that stopped the goblin in his tracks, for he just couldn't stand poetry.

"You saved me with your poem," said the grateful princess to the miner. "Are you a handsome prince in disguise?"

"No, I'm just a miner boy," said the ever-modest Curdy. "Although for a lonely miner, I'm quite courageous and have excellent hygiene."

"Oh," said the crestfallen princess. "Couldn't you go somewhere to learn to be a prince?"

"Like where?" asked Curdy. "How 'bout Princeton?"

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Oooof. That kind of talk makes the poetry seem appealing. Anyway, little did the princess know that the goblin who had chased her was himself a prince, the Prince of Goblins, and that he was determined to make her his bride. And so a pack of goblins-led by Prince Goblin-burrowed underneath the mountain precisely to the spot where the princess was, and popped up.

Actually, they made a slight miscalculation. They popped up in the middle of a croquet court. After a hasty retreat and a couple of aspirin (those croquet mallets aren't made of rubber, you know), the goblins tried again. They popped up and grabbed the princess! Well, actually, there was another slight miscalculation. They grabbed the hygienic miner instead.

"You fellows have made a terrible mistake," protested Curdy, as he was dragged into the mountain. "I'm Curdy!"

"You sure are, hun!" giggled the prince, not knowing what *curdy* meant, but thinking it sounded

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rather appealing.

So Curdy figured he would just recite a poem and make these goblins disappear. But without the princess to inspire him, Curdy couldn't think of a single rhyme. He could only think of words like *orange*. And *month*.

In no time at all, Curdy found himself in a very embarrassing position. Namely, standing next to Prince Goblin, dressed in a bridal gown.

"Do you take this earthling to be your lawful wedded wife?" a four-foot, two-inch minister asked the prince.

"Um, could you give me a second on that one?" requested the prince. "She looks a bit different than I remembered her." The prince decided to take Curdy out into the daylight for a closer look. Out they popped and who should Curdy see just outside the hole, but the princess herself. Finally inspired, Curdy burst into verse.

"What a gladsome fine surprise, to see you with mine eyes," he recited.

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The prince winced and cupped his ears.

"I love you more, my lovely princess, than pies of apples or minces."

At this, the prince could stand no more. He let go of Curdy and fled back to the mountain forever. The king was overjoyed to have his daughter back where she belonged.

"See," he said. "I told you the goblins will get you if you don't watch out."

"But you were wrong!" shouted Irene. "It's the love bug that gets you if you don't watch out."

Now *that's* a happy ending.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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